Operation 'Rah-e-Rast' was a success. However, Fazlullah and his main commanders escaped unhurt, which remained a matter of concern for the people of Swat. Many businessmen and traders were reluctant to return to their homes in Swat to reopen their small businesses. Although Operation 'Rah-e-Rast' was acclaimed within the country and abroad and cited as an example of the success of the military over militancy, those who wanted to see the top leadership of the TTP Swat chapter either captured or killed remained sceptical about its final success.

Fazlullah and some of his commanders, such as Ibne Amin of Matta, Mohammad Alam, alias commander Khalil of Fatehpur, and the most vocal Shah Dauran, who threatened people via FM radio, remained untraceable (*The News International*, 2009). But soon it became clear as Maulana Fazlullah claimed that he had safely crossed over to Afghanistan.

According to the BBC Urdu Service, the Maulana informed its Peshawar reporter that he was in Afghanistan and that his fighters would soon start guerrilla attacks against security forces in Swat. According to the report, Fazlullah read a written statement while speaking from a mobile phone having an Afghanistan code (*The News International*, 2009).

Fazlullah threatened that Information Minister NWFP (now KP) Mian Iftikhar Hussain, who was in the forefront in condemning the Taliban, would meet the same fate as late Afghan president Najibullah. It may be recalled that Najibullah was shot dead and then hanged, along with his younger brother Ahmadzai, in Aryana Square, Kabul, by the Afghan Taliban on 27 September 1996, the day they captured the city.

Brig. (retd) Mahmood Shah, former FATA secretary chief, stated that the escape of Fazlullah to Afghanistan was the failure of security forces. He said, 'It would be a great embarrassment for Pakistani and Afghan security forces if Fazlullah has crossed over' (*The News International*, 2009).

Despite this lapse, for which the army and people had to pay dearly afterwards, the successful offensive against the Taliban of Swat restored the credibility of the Pakistan military and hope in the people of Swat who were utterly dismayed before Operation 'Rah-e-Rast', wondering that the state would ever come to their rescue. The militants were also in high spirits. Many of their foot soldiers were heard boasting about their writ in Swat, and that the Pakistan government had ceased to exist in Swat (*The News International*, 2009). However, they were proven wrong.